January 2022 to 61.9 per cent today, a drop that coincides with the growing public discussion around a UCC. The findings point to the need to conduct serious deliberations with all communities so that policymakers can understand their concerns better.

A large number of respondents have pointed to the weakening of cooperative federalism in India, especially in light of the frequent face-offs between the Arvind Kejriwal-led Delhi government and the Centre. The MOTN survey shows that while 32.9 per cent of the respondents blame the National Democratic Alliance (NDA)-led Centre for it, almost an equal share of people—31.2 per cent—think the constant run-ins are because of the Delhi government. However, broadly, a majority of the respondents (61 per cent) believe that governors in non-BJP-ruled states behave in a partisan manner; only 21.9 per cent disagree. In fact, 37 per cent of the respondents also accuse India's poll watchdog, the Election Commission, of partisan conduct, though 49.5 per cent do believe it is fair.

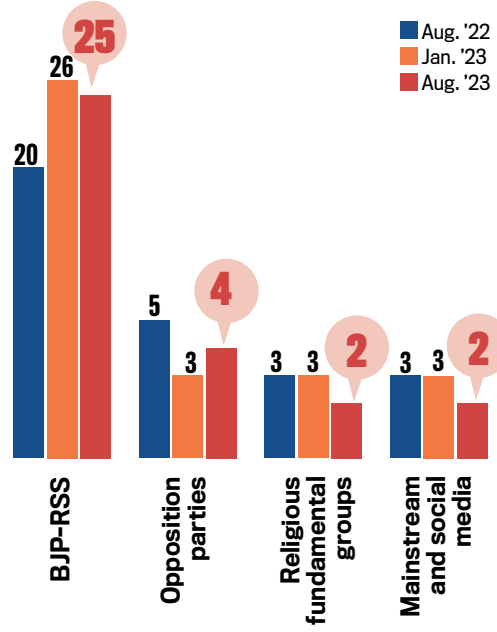
Beyond politics, the survey also reflects the lopsided nature of India's socioeconomic progress. Women's safety tops the list of areas that need work, despite the plethora of laws and gender justice measures being put in place. Only 36 per cent of the respondents in August 2023 feel India has become safer for women, in contrast to almost 50 per cent a year ago. In fact, those who say it has become less safe have gone up to 46.4 per cent from 34.4 per cent during the same period.

On the caste front, there has been only a slight shift in views on the subject of reservation for economically weaker sections (EWS). Almost 56.5 per cent of the respondents in the latest MOTN survey think such quota should have economic status and not caste as its criterion. This is only a marginal drop from 57.3 per cent in January 2023. Even the share of those who say both criteria should be considered is on the decline—28.6 per cent today compared to 32.3 per cent in January this year. Also, the total share of people who support inter-caste marriages totally or even conditionally (that is, when the caste identities are known to both parties), has dropped from 76 per cent in January this year to 72 per cent in the latest survey. Though what's of note is that 40 per cent upper-caste Hindus say they support inter-caste marriages if the caste identities are known to both parties.

Meanwhile, a few distinct steps taken by the Centre in recent years have elicited varying responses. The rewriting of history books, for instance. The past can be interpreted in numerous ways, and it's this fact that has divided opinions, with questions being raised about politics rather than a genuine academic need driving such changes. A majority of the respondents (54.7 per cent) think history books should be rewritten, while 30.8 per cent are opposed to the idea.

Next, it is the debate on freebies that seems to have divided respondents down the middle, with a little more than half (51.8 per cent) contending that the Centre and state governments

Q. If you think communal harmony in the country has deteriorated, who do you hold responsible for it?



The BJP-RSS still attracts the maximum blame for the deteriorating state of communal harmony in the country, though it has come down marginally from the previous MOTN

75%

CHRISTIANS, 62 PER CENT UPPER-CASTE HINDUS AND 61 PER CENT SIKHS SAY SCHOOL HISTORY BOOKS SHOULD BE REWRITTEN; 53 PER CENT MUSLIMS OPPOSE THE IDEA

39%

CHRISTIANS, HIGHEST AMONG ALL RELIGIOUS GROUPS, DON'T FEEL FREE EXPRESSING THEIR VIEWS ON POLITICS AND RELIGION

63%

MUSLIMS FEEL THEY ARE NOT SAFE IN INDIA

All figures in % and rounded off